Doing things that matter

If you didn't catch the live Apple iPhone 5S / 5C announcement on September 10, rest assured you didn't miss out on any moment of history. Don't believe me? Check it out on this month's DVD and see for yourself. Apple press conferences have stopped being charismatic and their products are anything but groundbreaking these days. Apart from that one particular moment, and no I'm not referring to the fingerprint sensor (which consumerises biometrics to a whole new level, signalling the beginning of the end of the traditional password). Phil Schiller's ecstatic declaration of the iPhone 5S to be the "first ever" smartphone to feature a 64-bit chip is a much bigger deal than one would imagine, for better or worse.

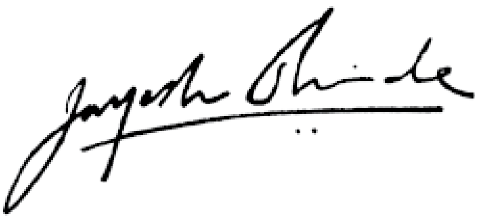
Yes, the 5S is the first smartphone to showcase a 64-bit chip, and yes Apple's putting a gargantuan marketing spin on the achievement, overselling its benefits in the near term – say, the next 2-3 years. Apple's phone may be the first to support 64-bit processing for now, but expect competing flagships to sport 64-bit chips by this time next year, according to ARM's 64-bit architecture roadmap. Not just Apple, companies like NVIDIA, Qualcomm, Samsung and Intel are all busy working on 64-bit chips. However, there are quite a few challenges to overcome for everyone to enjoy the benefits of 64-bit goodness.

A 64-bit chip is quite frankly wasted on a smartphone released in 2013. There just isn't enough RAM on devices to reap the benefits of 64-bit architecture – the Galaxy NOTE III is the current champion packing in 3GB – and it's safe to assume that with the 5S, Apple doesn't do any better. I'm quite sure Schiller wouldn't have kept it under wraps if the new iPhone 5S packed in a 4GB RAM module. With not enough system memory to enjoy most of the performance benefits, the whole point of a 64-bit chip is kind of wasted to begin with. Another thing to remember is that all the current smartphone OSes and the apps programmed to run on them right now only utilize a 32-bit address bus (because of the underlying hardware it's powered by). Until such time when the entire app development ecosystem shifts to 64-bit apps – and trust me, it's not going to happen in a hurry – you certainly won't be enjoying any of the software benefits of what 64-bit chips claim to offer. Why do you think Schiller added the bit about 32-bit apps running just as they should on the new 64-bit hardware? So don't get carried away with the whole 64-bit hype; wait and watch.

The point I'm trying to make is that it's inevitable that smartphones and tablets will be packed to the gills with hardware enhancements and even ridiculous features like picture-in-picture (watching two videos simultaneously on the same screen, why oh why?!). That's still fine, I guess. But wouldn't it be nice to address some basic problems like the abysmal battery performance on most smartphones these days – wouldn't it be nice to go through one whole day without having to charge your smartphone? Arguments can be made to justify that with every new hardware platform, battery efficiency of devices is improving. However, I think that's still attacking the problem through one perspective. It would be naive to assume bigger and brighter minds haven't thought of this already, but it's high time we were blessed with better performing batteries (may be something beyond Li-ion?) and not hardware components that leverage them better.

Screen sizes and form factors of devices is another aspect where there's a lot of craziness rampant in the industry right now. Phones measuring 6.5-inches long, tablets measuring 18-inches – what next? It's completely bonkers. Everyone's shooting darts at the spinning wheel with tens of hundreds of form factor combinations, leading to a tsunami of devices with little thought behind them. What OEMs term as choice, I like to call plain indecision. In time, this utter madness will abate. But for now, the freak-show continues. And there's no escaping it.

Oh Post-PC era, if I could only fathom what a splendid mess you would be? Alas, I had no such foresight. And, from the looks of it, neither did device manufacturers.



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